root.

How to tell if your dental website is doing *its job.*

Five quick checks now.
A deeper guide when you need it.

Can they find an answer?

Do they know what to expect?

Can they take the next step?

Five checks. *Phone in hand.*

Open your website and try these five checks. No worksheet required. You are looking for one useful thing to improve.

- [ ] ## Can someone call you?

  Tap the number from the homepage and a service page. **Good:** Your dialer opens with the correct office number.

  First fix: Put a working call link in the mobile header.

- [ ] ## What happens when you're closed?

  Find the emergency or contact information. **Good:** It explains the real after-hours process and who to contact.

  First fix: Publish those instructions beside the call option.

- [ ] ## Can someone schedule a visit?

  Follow the booking button; stop before submitting. **Good:** It opens the right practice and says whether you are requesting or booking a time.

  First fix: Fix the destination and make the label match the process.

- [ ] ## Can a new patient prepare?

  Find the team and first-visit information. **Good:** The team is identified, and arrival details and the usual first visit are explained.

  First fix: Add the answers your front desk gives most often.

- [ ] ## Can someone ask about cost?

  Find insurance and payment information. **Good:** Your actual policy and a way to ask about a specific plan are clear.

  First fix: Replace vague assurances with the policy your team uses.

Check what works. Start with the weakest one. That is enough for a useful first pass.

Inside this *guide.*

Have ten minutes? Start with page 2.
For a closer review, work through these three questions.

Can they find an answer? 04–08

A patient at 9 p.m., a worked Stillwater review,
and examples of useful answers.

Do they know what to expect? 09–13

Booking language, forms, services, first visits,
and insurance and payment information.

Can they take the next step? 14–19

Provider evidence, the first fix, a fillable worksheet,
and a finding someone can act on.

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It’s 9 p.m. *Their tooth hurts.*

The immediate question is simple: “What should I do next?” A website can answer it—or leave the patient guessing.

Imagine someone with a toothache opening a dental website after the office has closed. They are on a phone. They want to know who to contact and what happens tonight.

The first site has a friendly photograph and a booking button. Its phone number is in the footer. Nothing says whether an online request will be seen before morning.

A nearby office puts its call option beside clear instructions for after-hours contact. It has answered the question that matters in that moment.

Make the next decision easier.

Your site should describe the care and response process your practice actually provides. It does not need to promise evening coverage to explain what happens when you are closed.

Use the same test for a nervous new patient, someone checking insurance, or a parent booking for a child. Find the question, look for the answer, and follow the next step.

Use three honest results.

Works

The specific check succeeded.

Needs attention

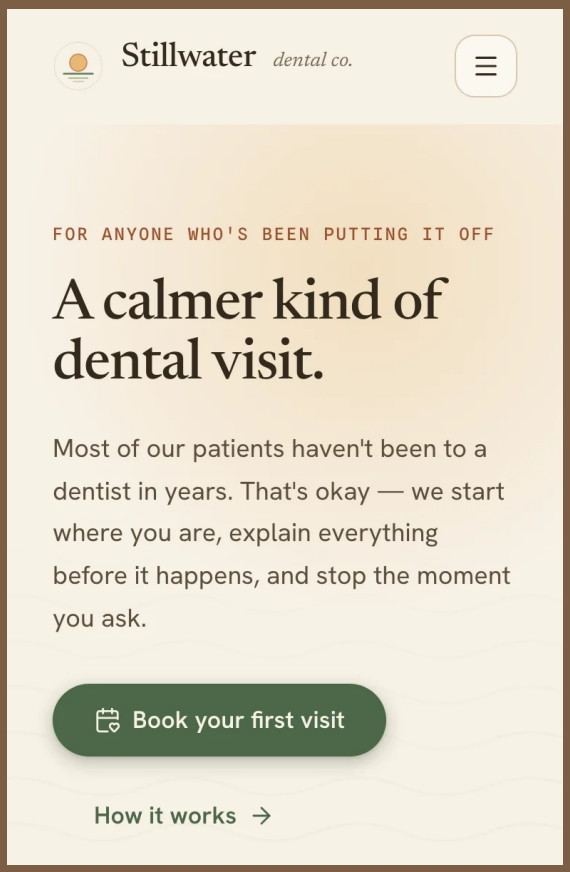
A missing answer or obstacle is visible.

Not verified

The outcome still needs evidence.

Follow one patient *through Stillwater.*

“I need to contact a dentist tonight.” Here is what I found in Root’s fictional demo before the update.



Before the update · Root demo.
Checked at 360 × 800
and 390 × 844.

Can I call right away?

Needs attention

At both phone sizes, booking appeared on the first screen. Calling required scrolling; no call button stayed on screen.

Is the number a call link?

Works · tap-to-call link

The number lower on the page linked to the same office number shown in the text.

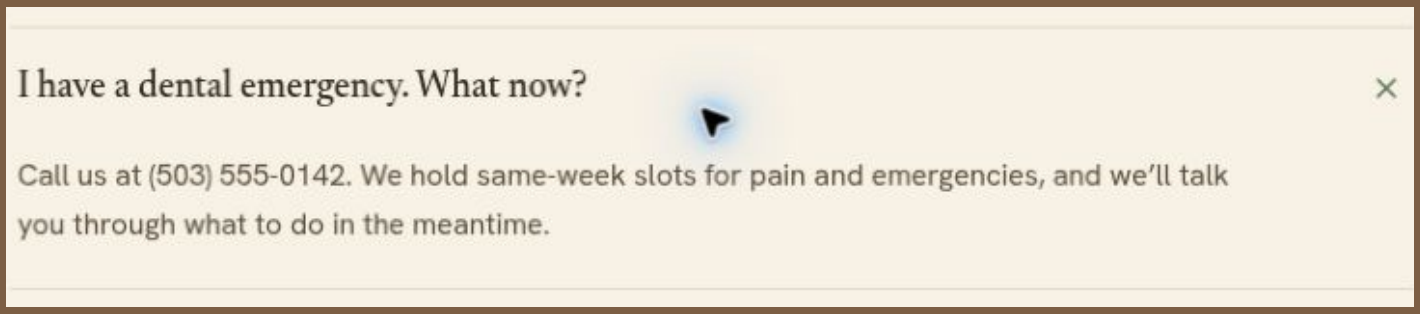
What happens tonight?

Needs attention

The emergency answer said to call and mentioned same-week slots. It did not explain what happened after closing.

The finding and *the first fix.*

The appointment pages opened. The missing answer was: “What happens if I need help after closing?”



Questions page · Emergency answer before the change.

The original route.

Works: “Book your first visit” opened the appointment pages. “Something hurts” led through comfort questions, time selection, and contact details.

Needs attention: Those pages gave no after-hours instructions. “Confirm my visit” did not explain whether staff needed to confirm the time.

The requested change.

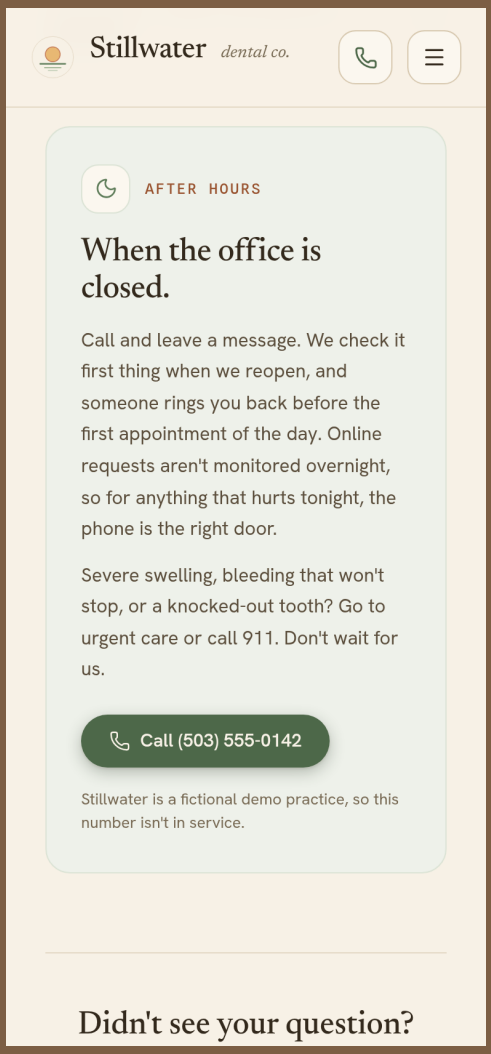
Put a call option on the first phone screen. Make the emergency answer’s number tappable, with clear instructions for when the office is closed.

At the urgent appointment step, explain what happens next and whether a selected time is confirmed.

Original check: October 28, 2026 (Central). No call was placed or form submitted. The next page shows the change and recheck.

Make the change. *Check it again.*

I made the changes, then repeated the same task on the live demo at both phone sizes.



Live site · October 28, 2026.
Phone view at 390 × 844.

Call from the first screen.

Works

At both phone sizes, the call option stayed visible while scrolling. Its link matched the displayed number.

Know what happens after hours.

Works

The example policy explains when messages are checked and calls returned. Online requests are not monitored overnight.

Know what the time means.

Works

The urgent path gives after-hours instructions. The selected time is a request until the team confirms it.

Website behavior checked; no call was placed, request submitted, or office response verified.

Put the answer *where it belongs.*

Use these examples as a bar for your own pages. The answer should be specific enough to help someone decide what to do.

“Can you help tonight?”	A call option beside your actual after-hours instructions. If you offer after-hours care, say exactly how to reach it.
“Do you offer this care?”	A clearly named service page that explains what your practice offers and how to discuss it with the dentist.
“What is my first visit like?”	Who the patient will meet, what to bring, how to arrive, and how to raise concerns before the visit.
“How does insurance work?”	Your current network or out-of-network policy, payment options, and a way to ask about an individual plan.
“How do I get a time?”	A visible action that reaches the correct practice and states whether the patient is requesting or booking an appointment.

A request or *a reserved time?*

A patient should know which one they have. The button, the form, and the confirmation must tell the same story.

Example: a request

Request an appointment.

Tell us how to reach you. Our team will contact you to schedule a time.

After sending:
Request received. Your appointment is not booked yet.

Example: live booking

Book an appointment.

Choose an available time and complete the booking steps.

After booking:
You’re booked for the time shown in your confirmation.

Read the confirmation, too.

Use booking language only when the system really books the time. A request receipt should explain how the team follows up, using a response window the practice can meet.

Make it work *on a real phone.*

Try the menu, a service page, and the form on your phone. A good path stays readable and makes each next action clear.

Read and move.

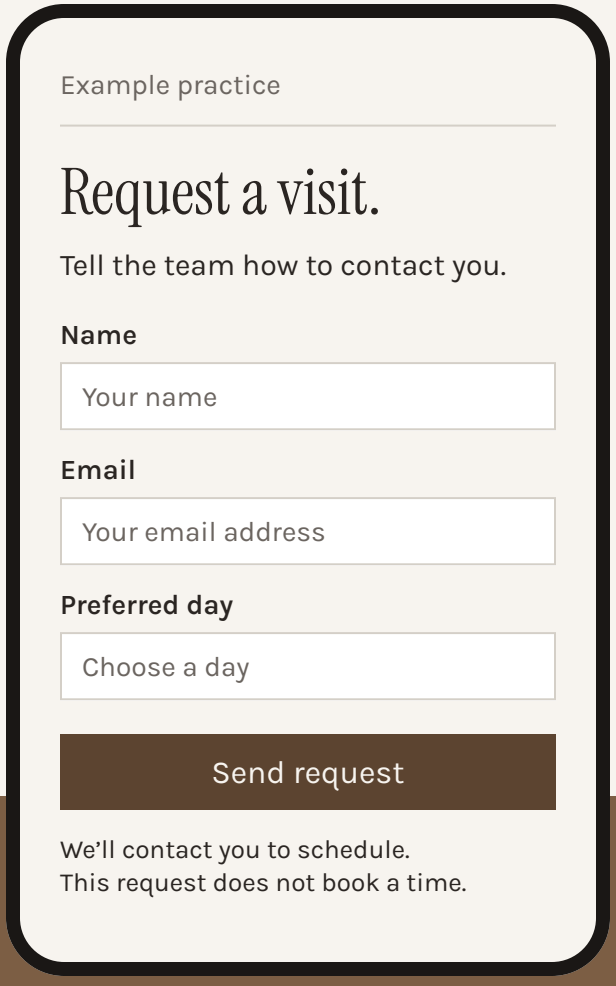
Text is readable without zooming. Menus open, close, and leave the contact option within reach.

Tap once.

Buttons respond where you expect. Banners do not cover the action, and links open the correct practice.

Check the form.

Labels stay visible. Errors explain the fix. Test with your team: the patient gets a clear confirmation, and the office receives the request.



Illustrative form layout.

Every field should have a visible label.

Explain the care *you actually offer.*

Good service copy connects a patient's question with the care available at your office.

Give the page a specific purpose.

Service names alone rarely answer what a patient wants to know.

Choose one service. Explain it in plain language, say what this office offers, and give a relevant next step.

Have the dentist review clinical copy. Keep claims about suitability, results, and timing aligned with what can be explained before an exam.

A useful page helps someone ask a better question.

Name the care.

Use the words patients recognize, with unfamiliar terms explained.

Describe your approach.

Say what is available at this practice and who provides it.

Answer a real concern.

Explain the practical next step for discussing options.

Offer a relevant action.

Help the reader ask about this service or schedule a visit.

Make the first visit *feel familiar.*

The bar is practical: a new patient can picture the people, the place, and the first steps before contacting you.

People they can recognize.

Use current names, roles, and real photographs. Make the dentist's qualifications clear. Remove biographies for people who have left.

An arrival they can picture.

Give the address, suite, entrance, and useful parking details. Test the map link. A map pin alone does not explain which door to use.

A visit they can understand.

Explain what your office usually asks new patients to bring or complete, who helps them get started, and the general first-visit process.

A way to raise concerns.

Give a clear contact route for questions about access or anxiety. Replace a broad promise of "gentle care" with an accurate explanation of what your team does.

Ask the front desk what patients *still need explained.*

Be clear about *insurance and payment.*

Have your front desk review the wording. Network status, coverage, and out-of-pocket costs are different questions.

Network

Submitting an insurance claim does not tell a patient whether you are in network. Explain your current network or out-of-network policy and how to check their particular plan.

Estimates

Show how someone can discuss likely costs with the team. Explain what a published price includes and when an exam or other information is needed before an estimate.

Payment

Name the options you actually offer. Give useful context for any membership, financing, or promotion, and keep its terms current. Provide a clear route for individual questions.

A specific policy is more useful *than "we work with insurance."*

Plan context: ADA's guide to dental plans

A click is not *the whole journey.*

The patient needs to know what happened. Your team needs to receive the request. The person maintaining the site should be able to show how both were checked.

At the button

The label matches the process that follows.

After submission

The patient sees a clear, accurate acknowledgment.

At the office

The right person receives it and knows who follows up.

Ask for a report. *Then ask what it proves.*

Ask your provider to show what was checked and what needs to change.

“How is the site performing on phones?”

A useful answer: dated reports for the homepage and booking entry page, with mobile and desktop results. The provider identifies real-user data versus a lab test and explains the first improvement.

Main content appears	Interactions respond	Layout stays stable
LCP · 2.5 seconds or less	INP · 200 milliseconds or less	CLS · 0.1 or less

Google’s “good” Core Web Vitals thresholds apply at the 75th percentile of real-user experience. A site may lack enough real-user data; lab tests still help diagnose issues.

“Can people use the important paths?”

A useful answer: automated results plus a record of manual checks on navigation, booking, and forms. Ask for a demonstration of keyboard use, visible focus, field labels, and error handling.

The bar: a provider can show what was checked, what failed, and how fixes were retested. A clean automated score alone does not establish accessibility.

Google’s thresholds · PageSpeed reports · W3C accessibility checks

Know who receives it. *Know what you own.*

The strongest answers include a record you can keep and a person who is responsible.

“Do our appointment requests arrive?”

Good evidence: a dated test record showing what the patient saw, where the office received the request, and who owns follow-up. Use test details and have staff confirm receipt. Repeat after form or booking changes and agree on recurring checks.

“What does the practice own?”

Good evidence: a written list of the domain, website source, content, hosting, and business accounts. It names owners, licensed assets, authorized access, and the transfer process. Have the provider walk through the list and confirm any missing access.

“How would we recover the site?”

Good evidence: what is backed up, who restores it, and what might need to be recreated. Ask for the date and result of a restore or recovery test, what it covered, and who owns any remaining gap.

Choose the first fix. *Make it count.*

Start with the problem that most affects the patient's next decision. You do not need a score to choose it.

1 It blocks the next step.

A wrong number, dead booking link, or request that never reaches the office prevents the intended action.

2 It creates the wrong expectation.

"Book now" sends a request, but the patient thinks the time is reserved. The words and the outcome need to agree.

3 It hides a useful answer.

Insurance details, the first visit, or after-hours instructions exist but are hard to find or understand.

Choose one change. Repeat the same patient task after it is made.

Your website *finding.*

Type into this page, then save the PDF. One clear finding is enough. In the HTML version, use Download notes to keep your entries.

Page address

Date and device

The patient’s question

What I tried

What happened

What should happen / first fix

Evidence or screenshot filename

Person responsible

Result after checking again

The worksheet, *filled in.*

Here is the Stillwater call-link finding in the same fields. Keep the original problem and the recheck together.

Page address

stillwater.demo.root.site/

Date and device

October 28, 2026 · 390 × 844

The patient's question

How can I contact a dentist tonight?

What I tried

I opened the homepage on a phone, looked for a call option, then scrolled.

What happened

Booking appeared on the first screen. Calling required scrolling, and no call option stayed visible.

What should happen / first fix

Keep a working call option visible on the first phone screen and while scrolling.

Evidence or screenshot filename

Before: page 5 · After: page 7

Person responsible

Platte, Root

Result after checking again

Works. On the live site, calling was visible immediately and while scrolling. The link matched the displayed number.

One person who knows *your website.*

Hi, I'm Platte.

I build and maintain websites for independent dental practices. I write the copy, handle the hosting and updates, and keep your Google Business Profile accurate.

You work directly with me. When your hours, team, or services change, email me. Routine changes are usually handled the same day.

That includes rechecking forms after changes, keeping contact details current, and fixing problems that get in a patient's way.

One flat monthly fee.
No setup cost. No contract.

platte@root.site



Platte Gruber
Founder, Root

Your website, *taken care of.*

Get three useful *findings. Free.*

Send me your website address. I'll review the public patient journey myself and send you three findings with screenshots **within two business days**: what's working, what's getting in the way, and what I'd change first.

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No charge. No obligation. Use the findings with your current provider, or talk with me about taking care of the website.